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Perfect defence: PSG lifted the UEFA Champions League trophy for a second consecutive year, ending Arsenal's hopes of a memorable double. AP

The glory trail

PSG, Barcelona Femeni and Al Nassr cap **remarkable campaigns** with silverware.



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Arsenal had toiled hard to shed the label of being 'bottlers' en route to its maiden Premier League crown in 22 years, besting Pep Guardiola's Manchester City in a down-to-the-wire title race. But a little over a week later, the Mikel Arteta-led Gunners stuttered against defending champion Paris Saint-Germain in the UEFA Champions League final, providing enough fodder for rivals to get back on the ridicule train.

Perhaps it was the momentous occasion of reaching the UCL final after two decades that got to Arsenal's young crop during the penalty

shootout, which it lost 3-4 to a PSG side that had lifted its maiden Champions League title just the year before.

The 120 minutes that preceded the decisive shootout were one-sided, to say the least. Yes, Arsenal did break the deadlock as early as the fifth minute through Kai Havertz's thumping strike from a narrow angle. But after that, the English side seemed to have brought its own double-decker bus from London and parked it at the Puskas Arena in Budapest. This allowed the French outfit to dominate possession — a staggering 72 per cent in the match — but Arsenal's resolute defence meant only a handful of PSG's 19 attempts were on target.

It took an Ousmane Dembele penalty in the 64th minute — after Khvicha Kvaratskhelia was